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Chapter 4

Practical living

As we have seen from the opening chapters, we have already started to learn from before the time of our birth, and this continues into our early years. Initially this learning is pre-conscious and pre-cognitive and through both our biological evolution and our development in the womb we bring to our lives predispositions that will affect our future learning: at birth we are by no means *tabula rasa*. Not only do we have predispositions – both learned and genetic – we are born into a world which has its own cultural history so that its people have devised their own answers to the problems generated by the fact that existence, the cosmos, and even being itself, have no in-built meaning. In other words, its cultures are responses to the problems that our predecessors faced at different times in their history, and it is this into which we are socialised and through which we build our own universe of meaning. However, this process occurs in the processes of living in society – a society that is changing very rapidly and it has made learning endemic! Bauman (2005: 1) opens his book *Liquid Life* in the following manner:

> Conditions of action and strategies designed to respond to them age quickly and become obsolete before the actors have chance to learn them properly.

Consequently, we live in a state of change all the time and that means that, unless we disengage from social living, we are constantly having potential learning experiences throughout the whole of our lives, and so we examine both action and the situation in this brief chapter.

Part 1: Action

Already we can begin to distinguish between the human condition and human nature: the human condition is ‘life itself, natality and mortality, worldliness, plurality, and the earth [which] can never “explain” what we are or answer the question of who we are for the simple reason that they never condition us absolutely’ (Arendt 1958: 11). Hence, we can already see two meanings to the word ‘meaning’: on the one hand, it is the meaning given to our experiences and, on the other, it is the meaning given to existence itself (see Chapter 6 for a discussion of meaning). Both of these are cultural phenomena. Later we will meet other meanings of this term, such as the meaning of phenomena, events, words, sentences, intentions, and so on. Human nature, however, also has at least two connotations – it is what we become as a result of our birth and learning. In a sense, there is a duality in human nature – that which is general to the human species and that which is specific to the individual. It will be recalled from earlier chapters, for instance, that, as a result of our early experiences, the neocortex of each individual is wired completely differently as a result of the patterns and networks of neurons that develop in our early years of life and which help form our perceptions of external reality. The

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building of our brain occurs, in part, as a result of those early learning experiences and continues at a slower rate as we age. It is, therefore, important to recognise that this process may well be different between the East and the West, and that we should not assume that we all undergo similar processes of wiring the neocortex.

Throughout these early chapters we have recognised the significance of relationship. Human living is about living in relationship with others and, in this sense, it is the 'living' rather than the 'learning' or the 'thinking' that has primacy to our being; this is not to say that thinking is not equally important, only that thinking occurs as a result of our living and not living as a result of our thinking. Arendt (1958) sees this as *Vita Activa* as opposed to *Vita Contemplativa* and, therefore, the importance of the worlds of labour and other forms of action, such as fabrication. In a different argument Archer (2000: 121–4) reaches a similar conclusion talking of the primacy of practice and she suggests that there are three pointers in this direction:

- Our embodiment.
- We all have transactions with reality from the first day of our lives.
- Our particular species-being has endowed us with various potentials, their development being socially contingent.

Husserl (cited in Schutz, 1967: 51) emphasised this when he wrote that 'I live *in* my Acts'. In precisely the same manner, Ricoeur, to whom we make reference later in this study, also starts with action:

> Ricoeur wants his thought to be rooted in the concreteness of human experience; everything must relate back, in one way or another, to human action.
>
> (Lowe, introduction to Ricoeur, 1986: x)

To be rooted in human experience is at the heart of our living. When we are taught we can learn *knowledge what* and even *knowledge how*, but this is as far as we can go. It is generalised information, and even if I learn it and make it my knowledge it is still insufficient. *Knowledge how* does not equip me to do anything – it is still in the cognitive domain. If I taught you how to play a game of cards, you still cannot play it until you have the cards in your hands and the experience of playing the game: this is the primary experience from which you learn. Now we learn from that experience and eventually we are *able to play*, but we also learn from that experience a different form of *knowledge how* and even *knowledge that* – now it is the subjective, personal knowledge learned from primary experience – it is our knowledge. But these forms of knowledge we may learn incidentally, or even pre-consciously in the process of doing. Since there is no conceptual relationship between the knowledge learned in secondary experience and *being able to* – we can learn that only by doing and having done and so we have learned our own knowledge – it has never been information or data and it only becomes data or information if we try to teach another. However, as we pointed out previously, once we do this, we are confronted with at least two insurmountable problems. First, once we try to put our experience into words, we can only speak from memory and, however immediate the memory, it is not the present, nor can we convey the sense of emotion contained in the experience or the learning that ensued. Second, experts in card playing may know all the rules but a great deal of their expertise lies not in rule-knowing but in the tacit knowledge of reading persons, situations or even the stage in the game. Tacit knowledge, as Polanyi (1967) showed us, is also an intrinsic part of our knowing, but it is one that we find difficult, if not impossible, to articulate.

In a different approach to practice, we find that Argyris and Schön (1974) start their study of 'theory in practice' from theory and apply it to practice; we will return to their work later. Their approach to theory needs careful and critical examination in the light of our understanding of learning, biography and behaviour: as a result of our previous learning and what we have learned to take for granted, it could be said that we develop a philosophy of behaviour and, as such,

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this could be conceived as a theory of action. In this sense, we develop implicit theories of action – tacit theories – so that it is impossible to divorce completely theory and practice and, in this sense, the claim would be true for Arendt, Archer and Ricoeur.

Unlike some of the of the early Enlightenment thinkers and those since that time who have embraced Enlightenment thinking, I feel – in common with a number of contemporary thinkers – that it is significant that we develop our understanding of human learning with and in practice, although laboratory experiments, and so on, may complement our understanding of practice. There is also a tacit theory in practical action itself and a more developed theory follows thereafter (see also Jarvis, 1999). This conclusion is important not only for our understanding of learning but also for our approaches to teaching. Significantly, it is in accord with Aristotle's formulation of practical wisdom when he emphasised that:

> What has been said is confirmed by the fact that while young men become geometricians and mathematicians and wise in matters like these, it is thought that a young man of practical wisdom cannot be found. The cause is that such wisdom is concerned not only with universals but with particulars, which become familiar from experience, but a young man has no experience, for it is length of time that gives experience.
>
> (Aristotle, 1925: VI.8, 148)

Theoretical subjects, then, might, but need not, be studied best by young people, but the practical business of living is something that can be mastered only by experienced people since it requires experience rather than scientific theory. We will return to the idea of agency in Chapter 13 when we look at doing.

Part 2: The situation

Much of our learning – even in everyday life – occurs in quite specific situations in our life-world, and it is necessary to recognise that our perception of the situation in which we are will affect our understanding of the event or its contents. In other words, we will see things culturally and individually as a result of our previous learning experiences, the memories of which are stored in our biographical history, and our biological history, which expands with age. Age is a major feature in our situation since we perceive the world differently as we age and so we are confronted with another basis for lifelong learning. But it is not only our biographical history that determines the way in which we perceive our situation; in every situation 'the ontological structure of the world is imposed upon me' (Schutz and Luckmann, 1974: 114). It is, for instance, a common experience to see people change their perceptions of a situation at work when they are promoted to a management position from that of an ordinary worker, when people age and retire, and so on. Learning is a personal, subjective construction of reality but it is also cultural. This may best be demonstrated by Witkin's (Witkin 1971) theory of field dependence: Nisbett (2005: 96–7) showed that Asian people are more field dependent than are Westerners. Consequently, they perceive situations and even causality differently, so that we can conclude that, generally speaking, perceptions of reality will differ between societies and cultures – although Nesbitt found that in some instances Western women approximated more closely to the Eastern perspective than did Eastern men. Therefore, there is a third element in this process, which is the phenomenological one, since it depends on the fact that where we are located socially will partially determine how we perceive a situation. However, even this is slightly oversimple because, if we are bicultural, our perception might be determined by the cultural framework within which we are functioning at that time. In my own experience of working in Hong Kong, one of the participants in a workshop which I facilitated was able to act in a Western manner, which accorded with her own experiences of being at university in

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Canada, when she was acting like a Western student and being the rapporteur for her group and speaking in English, but the following evening when she was not required to perform this role and she thought and acted as a Chinese student she was unable to speak out in the group and question the proceedings: she explained to me afterwards about why she was unable to play a Western student-type role on the second evening.

Generally we treat our situation as a fairly static phenomenon but we do have to recognise that the social structures of our life-world do change, often quite rapidly, and when they do all our taken-for-grantednesses and habits of daily living are destroyed and we have to discover new patterns for our lives. This is, in fact, a form of learning by doing. Aslanian and Brickell (1980) discovered that life transition is a major factor in people returning to studying – as it is to learning in general. The removal of social structures frees up individuals to do and learn new things. In the same manner, Lave and Wenger (1991) showed how we learn from and in our situation, which, in organisations, is a changing one as we become socialised into the organisation within which we are learning.

Perhaps the easiest way to depict the learning situations of everyday life is in Figure 4.1, in which it is recognised that both intended and unintended learning can occur in the same situation, whether it is formal, non-formal or informal.

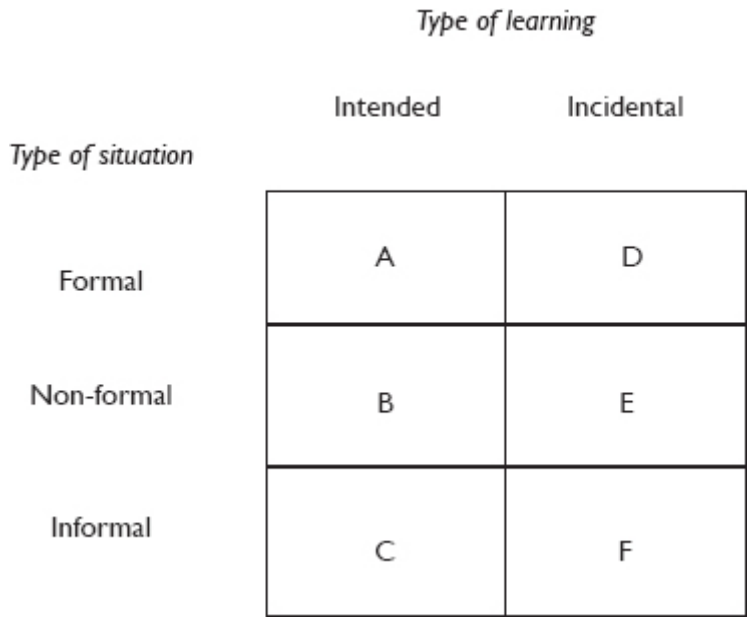


Figure 4.1 Possible learning situations.

We can now illustrate the type of learning that might occur in each of these six different learning situations.

- Box A is *formal education and training* that occurs in an educational institution and any other bureaucratic organisation devoted to education and training.
- Box B can refer to the ongoing nature of learning that occurs in places such as the work place, community, and so on. Sometimes the learner is actually mentored in these situations.
- Box C is both *learning in everyday life* and *self-directed learning*. It is the type of learning that we undertake when we decide to teach ourselves a computer program, and so on. It can be individual learning or part of a group project.
- Box D refers to that *incidental learning* that occurs in formal situations, not always educational, but which the planners of the learning experience do not intend. For example, the realisation that the instructor is not really as knowledgeable as we thought, or that the room is badly designed, or that teacher does not really treat me as an autonomous individual, and so on.
- Box E also refers to *incidental learning* situations in non-formal learning episodes.

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- Box F refers to *everyday learning*, which is probably the most common situation of all, especially in rapidly changing societies. In these we find ourselves in new situations and we have to learn how to cope – by thinking on our feet about our next action, and so on (Heller, 1984). If we fail to respond to this situation quickly, we usually have to plan our learning and then the situation moves to box C.

It is only in box A that we are expected to learn through secondary experience, which usually starts with a theoretical perspective – a legacy of the Enlightenment – although there are many other situations in which it occurs. However, the degree of formality is not the only variable in the subcultures of social situations that might affect either the type of learning or the behavioural outcomes of such learning: the politics and culture of the social context, the social position of both learners and teachers (leaders, managers, and so on) and even the status given to the knowledge being acquired will be amongst the factors that affect the type of experience from which the learners learn.

Understanding the situation, then, is a subjective but complex process, and in our everyday life we are quite likely to take for granted our social situation and even our perceptions of it. Indeed, we are mistakenly likely to regard them as objective.

Conclusion

It is in the situation that we have experiences in by and through which we learn, so that, before we look at the actual processes themselves, we do need to look carefully at the concept of experience itself.

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